

The Gospel of Philip

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Translated by: Wesley W. Isenberg

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Editor's Introduction

Introduced and translated by Wesley W. Isenberg

The Gospel of Philip is a compilation of statements pertaining primarily to the meaning and value of sacraments within the context of a Valentinian conception of the human predicament and life after death.

Like the gospels of the New Testament canon these statements employ a variety of literary types: aphorism, analogy, parable, paraenesis, polemic, narrative dialogue, dominical sayings, biblical exegesis, and dogmatic propositions. However, The Gospel of Philip is not a gospel like one of the New Testament gospels. To be sure, it does provide the occasional word or deed of Jesus. It contains seventeen sayings of Jesus, nine of which are citations and interpretations of Jesus' words already found in the canonical gospels (55,33-34; 57,3-5; 68,8-12; 68,26-27; 72,33-73,1; 77,18; 83,11-13; 84,7-9; 85,29-31). The new sayings (55,37-56,3; 58,10-14; 59,25-27; 63,29-30; 64,2-9; 64,10-12; 67,30-35; and 74,25-27), identified by the formula introducing them ("he said," "the Lord said," or "the Savior said") are brief and enigmatic and are best interpreted from a gnostic perspective. There are also a few stories about Jesus; they are similar to those in the early Christian apocryphal gospels. During a revelation on a mountain he appeared larger than life to his disciples (57,28-58,10). His three female companions were each named Mary (59,6-11), though he had an apparent preference for Mary Magdalene (63,32-36). After he had put seventy-two colors into a single vat in the dye-works of Levi, they coalesced into white (63,25-30). Philip the apostle is said to be the source of the story that Joseph the carpenter made the cross on which his offspring later hung (73,8-15).

These few sayings and stories about Jesus, however, are not set in any kind of narrative framework like one of the New Testament gospels. In fact, The Gospel of Philip is not organized in a way that can be conveniently outlined. Although some continuity is achieved through an association of ideas (cf. 51,29-52,35), a series of contrasts) or by catchwords (cf. 77,15-78,24, the word love), the line of thought is rambling and disjointed. Complete changes of subject are common.

The text gives the impression of logical coherence because of the recurrence of certain themes (e.g., the meaning of the names of Jesus, 56,3-15; 62,7-17; 63,21-24; the need to experience resurrection before one dies, 56,15-20; 56,26-57,22; 66,16-23; 73,1-8; putting on light to escape the hostile powers, 70,5-9; 76,22-77-1; 86,4-10), but this coherence is probably more coincidental than planned.

It is possible that the compiler of this collection purposely disjointed what were once whole paragraphs of thought and distributed the pieces in various places in this work. A clear thought results if one joins 70,5-9 with 76,22-77,1 and 66,7-29, in that order. Indefinite pronouns gain

proper antecedents in the process. Similarly 75,13-14 seems to provide the theme amplified by 61,36-62,5. In 63,5-11 one has the analogy prefacing the point made in 70,22-29.

Since The Gospel of Philip is eccentrically arranged, its contents can best be considered by reference to summarizing statements. The statement at 69,1-4 reflects a dominant concern, the mysteries of the bridal chamber, and distinguishes those who may participate - the free men and virgins - from those who may not - the animals, slaves, and defiled women.

Those excluded from the bridal chamber are described entirely in negative terms. We learn, *inter alia*, that animals and men must remain separate (78,25-28; 75,25-26). But “there are many animals in the world which are in human form” (81,7-8). If one is an “animal” he belongs “outside or below” rather than “above” or “within” (79,5-11). “Slaves” are to be contrasted with “sons” (52,2-6), with “children” (81,12-14) and with the “free” (79,13-18). A “slave” is one who commits sin (77,18), who is ignorant of the inner wickedness which enslaves him (83,18-29; 85,24). “Defiled women” are all women who participate in sexual intercourse, *i.e.*, in “the marriage of defilement,” which is fleshly and lustful (81,34-82,10). Unclean spirits seek to defile men and woman sexually (65,1-23).

“Free men and virgins” are the opposite of “animals, slaves, and defiled women.” A virgin has never been defiled by sexual intercourse (55,27-28; *cf.* 81,34-82,8). The “free man” does not sin (77,15-18). He neither fears the flesh nor loves it (66,4-6). He is endangered by the deceptions of the archons who seek to enslave him (54,16-31). “Free men and virgins” are those called “Christians” (74,13-16), who possess “the resurrection, the light, the cross, the holy spirit” (74,18-21).

According to this gospel the existential malady of humanity results from the differentiation of the sexes. When Eve was separated from Adam, the original androgynous unity was broken (68,22-26). The purpose of Christ’s coming is to reunite Adam and Eve (70,12-17). Just as a husband and wife unite in the bridal chamber, so also the reunion effected by Christ takes place in a bridal chamber, the sacramental one (70,17-22), where a person receives a foretaste and assurance of ultimate union with an angelic, heavenly counterpart (*cf.* 58,10-14).

This leads us to another summarizing statement (67,27-30), “The lord did everything in a mystery, a baptism and a chrism and a eucharist and a redemption and a bridal chamber.” The sentence probably describes five stages of a complete initiation, rather than five separate, unrelated sacraments. It is possible that “bridal chamber” is a covering term for the whole initiation, since a particular benefit of one stage of the initiation (*e.g.*, “light,” associated usually with chrism, 67,5-6; 69,12-14; 57,27-28) is also connected with bridal chamber (86,4-11; *cf.* 70,5-9). In 74,12-24 the person anointed in chrism is said to possess everything — resurrection, light, the cross, the holy spirit — but then the author adds, “the father gave him this in the bridal chamber.” Conversely, what one expects to be connected with bridal chamber appears in reference to eucharist (58,10-14) or baptism and chrism (69,4-14).

The Gospel of Philip does not describe, step by step, the ritual of all or any of the five stages of initiation. It does explain, however, that in baptism one “goes down into the water and comes up” with the gift of the name “Christian,” so that one can say, “I am a Christian” (64,22-31; *cf.* 77,9-12). The analogy of God as a dyer suggests that baptism was by immersion (61,12-20). The initiate takes off his clothes before entering the water so that he may put on the perfect man as a

new garment (75,21-25). That the chrism was a warm perfumed oil is apparent from references to the chrism as fire (67,5-9; 57,27-28) and to the oil as being fragrant (77,36-78,7; 82,15-23). Perhaps a trinitarian formula was used at the moment of anointing (67,19-24). The priest consecrates the bread and the cup for the eucharist (77,2-8). The consecrated cup contains wine mixed with water (75,14-21). The consecrated bread is "bread from heaven," food fit for the initiate (55,10-14). To partake of the bread and the cup is to receive "the flesh and the blood" of Jesus (56,26-57,22; cf. 63,21-24). A further ritual called ransom, or redemption, is mentioned, but no details are given. This stage of the initiation is compared to "the holy of the holy" in the Jerusalem temple and is said to take place in the bridal chamber (69,23-27).

Because of the contents, the eccentric arrangement, and the literary types exhibited, it is likely that The Gospel of Philip is a collection of excerpts mainly from a Christian Gnostic sacramental catechesis. It explains the significance of sacramental rites of initiation, the meaning of sacred names, especially names of Jesus, and provides paraenesis for the life of the initiated. It interprets Biblical passages, particularly from the book of Genesis, makes use of typology, both historical and sacramental, and, as catechists do, argues on the basis of analogy and parable. In these and other ways The Gospel of Philip resembles the orthodox catechisms from the second through fourth centuries.

The title of this text may be derived merely from the fact that Philip is the only apostle named in it (73,8), though Philip, along with Thomas and Matthew, had an eminence among Gnostics as a privileged recipient and custodian of dominical revelation. The Coptic text is undoubtedly a translation of a Greek text which was written perhaps as late as the second half of the third century C.E. Because of the interest in the meaning of certain Syriac words (63,21-23; 56,7-9), its affinities to Eastern sacramental practice and catecheses, and its ascetic ethics, an origin in Syria is probable.